

From Lahore to Sharjah: A journey through cricket's timeless charm

Lahore's cricketing soul shines through Saqlain's nostalgia and historic museums, while Sharjah's fading legacy reminds us of cricket's **ever-evolving journey** from past glories to modern spectacles.

It was a chilly Wednesday night in Lahore when we stood outside Chaman, the iconic ice cream parlour in Laxmi Chowk. Saqlain Mushtaq, our guide for the evening, smiled as he ordered, "*Teen pistachio... yeh sabse badiya hai. Hum bachpan se khaa rahein hain.*" As we indulged in the sweet treat, he pointed to a nearby ground and said, "This is where it all started. This is where we would play cricket."

Between bites of ice cream, Saqlain reminisced about mastering the *doosra* on his rooftop, never imagining a future with 496 international wickets. "Ramzan nights meant cricket till *sehri*," he said, a nostalgic glint in his eyes.

Soon, nostalgia turned to action. Spotting a group of youngsters playing street cricket, he couldn't

resist. As he stepped out of the car, stunned players gasped, "Saqlain bhai?" He took guard, flicked a few deliveries, then unleashed his signature spin. The first was a classic off-spinner; the second, a *doosra* — both unplayable. The kids cheered, posed for photos, and collected autographs (**pic, facing page**).

As we drove through Lahore's historic streets, Saqlain spoke of its cricketing legacy. "This is Wasim bhai's *ilaka*," he said, pointing down a lane. "Back then, no smartphones — just cricket, school, and the streets."

Even as Pakistan struggles to find world-class spinners, Saqlain remains hopeful. Cricket shaped his childhood, and on

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